

What makes a society successful?

An economy grows. A government survives. An empire expands. Hilary Putnam and The Entanglement of Fact and Value

FACT

+

VALUE

not two sealed boxes

Hilary Putnam - The Entanglement of Fact and Value

What would make these achievements worth celebrating?

Social science explains how societies work

1

Economics investigates production, wages, investment, and employment.

2

Political science investigates power, cooperation, conflict, and institutional survival.

3

History investigates how people and institutions changed.

We also want to understand whether those changes improved human life.

An economy grows. Are people better off?

5%

GDP growth

Median purchasing power remains unchanged.

Working hours increase.

Preventable illness becomes more common.

Has this country made progress?

“Progress” requires a standard

Different standards bring different features into view:

- Production: How much does the economy produce?
- Living standards: What can ordinary households afford?
- Well-being: How healthy, secure, and fulfilled are people?
- Freedom: What meaningful choices can people make?

Agreeing on the measurements does not settle which standard best captures progress.

A useful distinction can become a sweeping claim

DESCRIPTIVE

Descriptive claims: “Average working hours increased.”

EVALUATIVE

Evaluative claims: “These working conditions are unacceptable.”

Putnam challenges this stronger position. Merely distinguishing description from evaluation does not establish it.
Putnam's book

Descriptions can be objectively justified; evaluations ultimately express preferences.

Equal income can conceal unequal opportunities

SIDE A

One can travel and work without additional assistance.

SIDE B

The other needs expensive mobility support and faces inaccessible transport.

Their purchasing power is equal, but their practical opportunities differ.

What would an adequate comparison of their circumstances measure?

A better question can reveal overlooked facts

Amartya Sen proposes examining people's capabilities: their actual opportunities to do and be things they have reason to value.

1

Mobility and accessibility.

2

Nutrition and shelter.

3

Participation in community life.

Satisfaction can be an incomplete measure

People can adapt to difficult circumstances and lower their expectations.

1

Reported satisfaction tells us something important.

2

It can coexist with restricted opportunities.

3

Deciding whether it adequately measures well-being requires further judgment.

Does becoming accustomed to deprivation make deprivation disappear?

A deeply unequal allocation can be efficient

99

1

- 
- The supply is fixed.
 - Each person prefers having more.
 - Neither cares about the other's allocation.

Efficiency answers a limited question

99 / 1

Pareto efficient



50 / 50

Pareto efficient



The 99–1 allocation is Pareto efficient: no feasible change helps someone without hurting someone else. Under the same assumptions, 50–50 is also Pareto efficient. The criterion does not tell us which distribution is fair.

Mathematical precision does not make a criterion morally sufficient.

Can we criticize our measures of success?

Suppose a welfare measure systematically overlooks serious, avoidable suffering.

1

It may omit conditions central to people's lives.

2

It may treat relevantly different circumstances as equivalent.

3

It may reward outcomes that undermine its stated purpose.

Can we give reasons for changing it?

A government can survive through different means

A political model might explain stability through:

- Reliable taxation.
- Effective administration.
- Cooperation among powerful groups.
- Public support—or effective intimidation.

Explaining why a government survives leaves open whether its survival is desirable.

Public order needs interpretation

Imagine that demonstrations sharply decline.

- Citizens are more satisfied.
- Grievances have been addressed.
- Organizing has become dangerous.
- People believe protest is futile.

Possible explanations include: The same headline statistic can accompany very different political conditions.

We need to investigate what the silence means.

Power, acceptance, and justification differ

POWER

The government secures obedience.

How effective is its power?

BELIEF

Citizens believe it has a right to rule.

What do citizens believe?

JUSTIFICATION

It has a right to rule.

Is its authority justified?

Institutions embody choices that remain open to criticism

Property rules, voting procedures, and tax systems organize whose claims receive recognition.

1

How did these arrangements
emerge?

2

What consequences do they
produce?

3

What reasons support keeping or
changing them?

The fact that earlier values shaped an institution does not establish that its present rules are justified.

Historical questions shape what becomes visible

Consider a history of an empire.

A focus on administration directs attention to taxes, roads, and military organization.

A focus on ordinary life directs attention to labor, displacement, security, and household survival.

Historians' perspectives influence inquiry while remaining answerable to the record. AHA standards

The questions we consider important shape the evidence we seek.

Frederick Douglass challenged an interpretation

In his 1845 autobiography, Douglass described people mistaking enslaved people's singing for evidence of contentment.

He explained that, in his experience, singing often expressed or relieved sorrow.

Listening to the people being described can correct an observer's interpretation.
Douglass, Chapter II

An apparently familiar behavior had been misunderstood.

Historical judgment requires discipline

Taking people's experiences seriously requires careful evidence.

- Read sources in their historical context.
- Investigate disagreements among people at the time.
- Examine evidence that challenges your interpretation.
- Separate explaining an action from defending it.

AHA standards for historical scholarship

A moral commitment does not excuse a distorted account of the past.

Our judgments about the past shape future goals

Imagine evaluating a past government.

1

If success means survival, we may emphasize preserving authority.

2

If success includes public security, we investigate whose security improved.

3

If success includes freedom, we investigate people's ability to challenge power.

Historical lessons depend partly on what we judge worth repeating.

Interaction alone does not prove entanglement

SIDE A

SIDE B

Values influence research questions and institutions.

Evidence can change evaluations.

Measures of success need justification.

Putnam's stronger challenge concerns whether description and evaluation can always be cleanly separated.

Some concepts describe and evaluate together

CRUEL

HONEST

COURAGEOUS

Philosophers call these thick ethical concepts. They characterize conduct while also carrying evaluative significance.

Can we fully explain what such a concept means by separating neutral description from approval or disapproval?

What makes an action cruel?

Imagine a teacher repeatedly ridiculing a struggling student.

- What suffering or humiliation occurred?
- What did the teacher understand?
- How vulnerable was the student?
- What reasons, if any, justified the conduct?

Assessing cruelty involves questions such as:

Pain alone cannot settle the judgment: necessary medical treatment can also hurt.

Putnam challenges the proposed separation

SIDE A

Can the neutral description identify everything relevant to cruelty?

SIDE B

Do terms such as “gratuitous” or “humiliating” reintroduce evaluation?

Can the separation preserve the concept across different cases?

Scientific inquiry also depends on standards

Scientists assess explanations using:

- Fit with evidence.
- Coherence.
- Explanatory power.
- Simplicity, where appropriate.

These are epistemic values: standards for good inquiry. Putnam emphasizes that judging a theory worthy of acceptance involves standards about how we ought to reason. Putnam, “Beyond the Fact/Value Dichotomy”

Disagreement does not automatically defeat rational judgment

Researchers can disagree about:

1

Which explanation is more adequate.

2

Whether an assumption is reasonable.

3

How to weigh competing theoretical virtues.

The strongest objection distinguishes kinds of value

SIDE A

Science needing standards does not automatically establish moral objectivity.

SIDE B

Putnam must explain why ethical judgments can also be justified.

That objection deserves an answer.

The argument puts pressure on the divide; further reasoning is still required.

Entanglement does not settle every moral question

Putnam's challenge does not establish that:

- Every factual statement is a moral judgment.
- Every sincere evaluation is correct.
- Economic growth automatically creates an obligation.
- One political system follows uniquely from the evidence.

A premise such as “this policy is cruel” already contains evaluation.

Using that premise does not derive morality from wholly neutral premises.

Evaluative standards can themselves face criticism

Suppose we call a policy fair because everyone receives the same payment.

- Does equal payment address substantially different needs?
- Does the rule serve its stated purpose?
- Can its justification survive relevant counterexamples?
- What evidence would make us revise it?

We can examine that standard:

Evaluation can involve argument, investigation, and correction.

The larger issue is the reach of reason

The stakes extend across disciplines:

- Economics: Can we justify what counts as welfare?
- Politics: Can we assess authority as well as explain power?
- History: Can we defend judgments about progress and failure?
- Science: How do standards of good inquiry earn their authority?

Can reason help assess our goals as well as our methods?

Why read Putnam?

**HILARY
PUTNAM**

**The Entanglement
of Fact and Value**

2002 - Chapter 2 - pp. 28-45

- Can understanding a human situation require evaluative concepts?
- Can value judgments be rationally justified?
- What would objectivity require if inquiry includes values?

Understanding how a society works raises the further question of what makes it worth sustaining.

Credits

Original visual direction: Ecology Infographics by Slidesgo.
Deck rebuilt for readability from the Markdown source in the repository.